STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

MENTAL HEALTH AT WORK

What the WHO guidelines of 2022 put first, how many working-age adults live with a mental disorder, six places to act, how strong the evidence is, what German law asks, and a card for one strain.

12 bn working days are lost every year to depression and anxiety, costing the global economy nearly US$1 trillion.

WHO & ILO, 2022

INSIDE

COVER STORY

From the person to the work

PAGE 03

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

How strong the evidence is

PAGE 06

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

One strain, one measure

PAGE 08

NO. 75 · PEOPLE

In this issue

Mental health at work is often handled as a matter for the individual: an app, a course, a hotline. The WHO guidelines of 2022 start somewhere else, with workload, control and how people treat each other. This issue asks what that means for a manager.

The WHO estimates that 15% of working-age adults had a mental disorder in 2019, and that depression and anxiety cost about 12 billion working days a year. Its guidelines recommend changing the work to reduce psychosocial risks and, for the first time, training managers. The evidence for manager training is the strongest; for changing the work it is very uncertain, probably because such changes are hard to study. German law already asks employers to assess psychological strain. The issue describes evidence; it is not medical advice.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

03 COVER STORY
From the person to the work

04 THE NUMBERS
Three in twenty

05 THE MODEL
Where to act

06 WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS
How strong the evidence is

07 HOW IT IS MEASURED
What German law asks

08 TOOL OF THE ISSUE
One strain, one measure

09 SOURCES
Sources and method

HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

From the person to the work

On 28 September 2022 the WHO published its guidelines on mental health at work, together with a policy brief written with the International Labour Organization. They begin with the conditions of work.

Risks at work the WHO names

1. excessive workload or work pace, understaffing
2. little control over job design or workload
3. violence, harassment or bullying
4. discrimination and inequality
5. job insecurity

The launch named what was new in them:

“For the first time WHO recommends manager training, to build their capacity to prevent stressful work environments and respond to workers in distress.”

OUR READING

Workload, control and behaviour are decided at work, often by the manager. That is where the WHO starts.

Sources: World Health Organization, 2022 (via NCBI Bookshelf text and summaries, through web search); World Health Organization & International Labour Organization, 2022 (via Text of the release through web search; UN News); World Health Organization, 2024 (via Text of the fact sheet, through web search)

The list shortens the WHO fact sheet; translations are ours. Burnout is No. 29, psychological safety No. 4. This issue describes guidelines and evidence; it is not medical advice.

THE NUMBERS

Three in twenty

The WHO's World Mental Health Report of 2022 estimated that about one billion people lived with a mental disorder in 2019. Among adults of working age, the share was 15%.

WORKING-AGE ADULTS WORLDWIDE, 2019, OUT OF 20



3 in 20
had a mental disorder (15%)

17 in 20
the rest

≈ 12 bn
working days lost each year to depression and anxiety

≈ $1 tn
the yearly cost to the global economy

35%
of countries reported national programmes for mental health at work

OUR READING

In a team of twenty, three people living with a mental disorder is the average expectation, not a rare case.

Sources: World Health Organization, 2022 (via WHO/ILO news release of 28 September 2022); World Health Organization & International Labour Organization, 2022 (via Text of the release through web search; UN News)

Global estimates, not counts. A disorder is a diagnosis, not the stress of a hard week. Days, cost and the 35% are as the WHO and ILO gave them in 2022.

THE MODEL

Where to act

The guidelines recommend action in these areas. They run from the work itself, through the people who lead it, to workers who live with a mental health condition.

01	**Organisational interventions**	reduce psychosocial risks such as bullying or low job control
02	**Manager training**	knowledge, attitudes and skills; not meant to turn managers into therapists
03	**Worker training**	mental health literacy and awareness
04	**Individual interventions**	psychosocial support or physical activity, as one part of a wider programme
05	**Return to work**	work-directed care, such as a phased return, with ongoing clinical care
06	**Gaining employment**	supported employment for people with severe conditions

OUR READING

Help for the individual is on the list, but as one part. It does not replace changing the work that strains everyone.

Sources: World Health Organization, 2022 (via NCBI Bookshelf text and summaries, through web search); Aiysha Malik, José Luis Ayuso-Mateos, Gergő Baranyi, Corrado Barbui, Graham Thornicroft, Mark van Ommeren & Aemal Akhtar, World Psychiatry 22(2), 2023 (via Text of the article (PMC), through web search); World Health Organization, 2024 (via Text of the fact sheet, through web search)

Rows shortened from the guidelines and Malik et al. (2023). The fact sheet adds reasonable accommodations, such as flexible hours or extra time for tasks. On screening workers, the WHO made no recommendation.

More in the essay Leadership without a title

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

How strong the evidence is

With the GRADE method the WHO rates each recommendation twice: how strong it is, and how certain the evidence behind it is.

01	**Manager training**	strong recommendation, moderate certainty
02	**Organisational interventions for all**	“may be considered”: conditional, very low certainty
03	**Mental health training for workers**	conditional, very low certainty
04	**Leadership-oriented training**	no recommendation: no clear effect on health
05	**Screening workers**	no recommendation: unclear if benefits outweigh harms

OUR READING

Weak evidence for changing the work is not proof that it fails. Such changes are hard to study, and the law does not wait for the trials.

Sources: World Health Organization, 2022 (via NCBI Bookshelf text and summaries, through web search); Aiysha Malik, José Luis Ayuso-Mateos, Gergő Baranyi, Corrado Barbui, Graham Thornicroft, Mark van Ommeren & Aemal Akhtar, World Psychiatry 22(2), 2023 (via Text of the article (PMC), through web search)

Low certainty means more research could change the estimate. Malik et al. (2023) trace the weak evidence to how hard complex interventions are to evaluate. Grades for the two trainings are from independent summaries.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

What German law asks

Germany's Occupational Safety and Health Act (Arbeitsschutzgesetz) lists psychological strain at work among the sources of hazard for the employer's risk assessment (§ 5(3) no. 6). Read together, four steps:

1. **Assess (§ 5)**
   which hazards come with the work, by type of activity; similar jobs may share one assessment
2. **Act at the source (§ 4)**
   design work to spare physical and mental health; individual measures come after the others
3. **Check (§ 3)**
   whether the measures work, and adapt them when conditions change
4. **Document (§ 6)**
   the result of the assessment, the measures and the result of their review

OUR READING

The law and the WHO point the same way: the work first, the person after. A questionnaire is not yet an assessment; the measures and their review belong to it.

Source: Federal Republic of Germany, Bundesgesetzblatt I 1996 p. 1246, 2021 (via Mirror at github.com/bundestag/gesetze)

Our summary of §§ 3–6, not legal advice. The Act prescribes no method for the assessment. We did not check the law in Albania.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

One strain, one measure

One card per task or team. It asks about the work, not about anyone's health: what strains, where it comes from, what changes at the source, and when you check. Five Whys helps with the third line.

01 Task or team where, which shift, how many people

02 The strain load or pace, control, staffing, behaviour, insecurity: which, how often

03 Where it comes from ask why until you reach something in the work

04 Measure at the source what changes in the work, before training or individual help

05 Who and by when one owner, one date; ask the team what they would change

06 Check and record did the strain go down; where it is written down

Sources: World Health Organization, 2022 (via NCBI Bookshelf text and summaries, through web search); Federal Republic of Germany, Bundesgesetzblatt I 1996 p. 1246, 2021 (via Mirror at github.com/bundestag/gesetze)

A practice proposed by the editors, after the WHO's order and §§ 3–6 of the Arbeitsschutzgesetz. It is not a diagnosis and replaces neither the formal risk assessment nor medical help.

Open the tool: 5 Whys stivencatalyst.com/tools/five-whys/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

WHO guidelines on mental health at work
World Health Organization, 2022 · via NCBI Bookshelf text and summaries, through web search
https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240053052

WHO and ILO call for new measures to tackle mental health issues at work (news release, 28 September 2022)
World Health Organization & International Labour Organization, 2022 · via Text of the release through web search; UN News
https://www.who.int/news/item/28-09-2022-who-and-ilo-call-for-new-measures-to-tackle-mental-health-issues-at-work

Mental health at work (fact sheet)
World Health Organization, 2024 · via Text of the fact sheet, through web search
https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/mental-health-at-work

World mental health report: Transforming mental health for all
World Health Organization, 2022 · via WHO/ILO news release of 28 September 2022
https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240049338

Mental health at work: WHO guidelines
Aiysha Malik, José Luis Ayuso-Mateos, Gergő Baranyi, Corrado Barbui, Graham Thornicroft, Mark van Ommeren & Aemal Akhtar, World Psychiatry 22(2), 2023 · via Text of the article (PMC), through web search
https://doi.org/10.1002/wps.21094

Arbeitsschutzgesetz (Occupational Safety and Health Act), §§ 3–6, as last amended on 22 November 2021
Federal Republic of Germany, Bundesgesetzblatt I 1996 p. 1246, 2021 · via Mirror at github.com/bundestag/gesetze
https://www.gesetze-im-internet.de/arbschg/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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